OpenClaw System Prompt Words

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1. Course Content

Course Overview

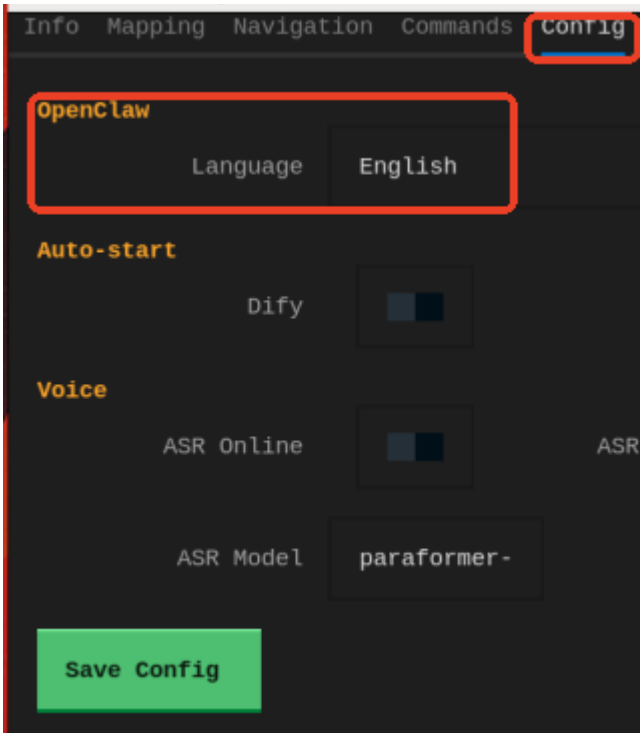
- 💡 OpenClaw adopts an innovative **"file as prompt"** architecture — the AI Agent's behavior, identity, memory, tool usage rules, etc., are all defined and loaded through multiple Markdown files in the Workspace.

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2. 📂 Switch Workspace (Configurable Only for International Users)

- OpenClaw's system prompt words and skills are all stored under the `$HOME/.openclaw/workspace` workspace path
- The factory preset includes different workspace contents in Chinese and English; the content meaning is the same, only the language differs
- Users in different regions can switch the language of the openclaw workspace documents as needed. **The factory default OpenClaw system prompt words are in Chinese.**
- Switch the OpenClaw system prompt words to English

```
robot_manage gui
```



- After configuration is complete, restart the openclaw gateway to apply the configuration

```
openclaw gateway restart
```

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3. AGENTS.md

- Function Description

AGENTS.md defines the top-level specifications for how the Agent operates in the workspace. 📖 It can be understood as the Agent's **"user manual"** — telling the Agent how to start up, how to manage memory, what things it can do, and what things it absolutely cannot do.

- Content Structure

AGENTS.md mainly includes the following core sections:

Section	Description
First Run	Guides the Agent's initialization process during first startup (reads BOOTSTRAP.md)
Physical Body	Describes the Agent's physical carrier (robotic arm, chassis, camera) and control methods
Session Startup	Specifies the startup process and file reading order for each session
Memory System	Defines the layered architecture of daily records and long-term memory
Red Line Rules	Lists absolutely prohibited behaviors (destructive commands, modifying robot program code)

Section	Description
Operation Specifications	Distinguishes between operations that can be freely executed and operations that require prior inquiry
Memory Maintenance	Memory organization and update mechanism during heartbeat

> **Note**
>
> ⚠️ The factory AGENTS.md prompt restricts OpenClaw from modifying robot program code

4. SOUL.md

- Function Description

SOUL.md is the Agent's **"soul" and kernel** 🧠. It defines the Agent's thinking methods and behavioral guidelines when facing tasks — how to control the robot body, how to find and use skills, how to plan and execute actions, and under what circumstances it should pause or refuse execution. SOUL.md shapes the Agent's core behavioral pattern as a "robot operator".

- Working Principle

SOUL.md is read by the Agent at session startup as the underlying guiding principle for task execution. It does not specify concrete skill parameters but rather defines **what kind of thinking process the Agent should use when encountering any task**. For example, the Agent is forced to check the skill library before starting any task, and cannot execute directly based on feeling or memory — this habit of "checking documentation before doing work" is defined by SOUL.md.

5. IDENTITY.md

- Function Description

IDENTITY.md defines the AI Agent's **self-awareness and personality characteristics**. It defines who the Agent "is" — its name, personality, language style, and basic identity positioning. This file gives the Agent a consistent personality when interacting with users.

- Working Principle

At each session startup, the Agent reads IDENTITY.md and establishes "self-awareness" based on it. This information affects the Agent's tone when answering questions, the way it proactively offers help, and the style it uses to build relationships with users. For example, an Agent set to be "friendly and gentle" will naturally use more approachable language when replying to users.

6. HEARTBEAT.md

- Function Description

HEARTBEAT.md is the configuration file that controls the **heartbeat detection mechanism** in OpenClaw ⏰. The heartbeat mechanism allows the Agent to periodically "wake up" and execute background checks and maintenance tasks without user-initiated sessions. This is similar to robot automatic timed inspection — the Agent can silently complete memory organization, status checks, and other work in the background.

- Working Principle

The OpenClaw Gateway periodically checks the content of the HEARTBEAT.md file to decide whether to trigger the Agent's heartbeat API call:

- **File is empty or contains only comments**: Skip the heartbeat call; the Agent will not be woken up in the background

> **Note**
>
> The factory configuration of the robot has the heartbeat mechanism turned off by default.

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7. TOOLS.md

- Function Description

TOOLS.md is the Agent's **localized notes for tool usage** . In the OpenClaw system, "Skills" define the general working methods of tools, while TOOLS.md records the Agent's own unique configurations and personalized settings. Simply put: Skills are instruction manuals (general), and TOOLS.md is your personal notes (unique).

- Working Principle

During a session, the Agent reads both the relevant Skills documentation to understand the general usage of tools and reads TOOLS.md to obtain configurations related to its own deployment environment.

8. USER.md

- Function Description

USER.md is the dedicated file for the Agent to **understand and remember user information**. If IDENTITY.md is the window for the Agent to understand "who I am", then USER.md is the window for the Agent to understand "who you are interacting with". It records the user's basic information, preferences, project background, and other contextual information, helping the Agent provide more personalized and thoughtful service.

- Working Principle

At each session startup, the Agent reads USER.md according to the process specified in AGENTS.md. Through this file, the Agent can:

- Know how to address the user (name, form of address)
- Understand the user's timezone, preferences, and other background information
- Remember things the user cares about and projects in progress

9. MEMORY.md

- Function Description

MEMORY.md is the AI Agent's **long-term memory file** . In OpenClaw's memory system, there are two levels of memory storage:

1. **Daily Records** (`memory/YYYY-MM-DD.md`): Records raw events and dialogue logs that occur each day, similar to a human's "diary"

2. 🗂️ **Long-term Memory** (`MEMORY.md`): Refined information extracted from daily records, similar to a human's "long-term memory" — containing important events, learned experiences, key decisions, and insights

- Working Principle

The loading and use of MEMORY.md follows these rules:

- **Loaded only in main sessions**: When the user directly converses with the Agent, the Agent reads MEMORY.md to obtain long-term memory
- **Maintained autonomously by the Agent**: The Agent can freely read, edit, and update MEMORY.md during main sessions

> **Note**
>
> In actual user practice, you can:

- ✏️ **Proactively write important information**: Write content you think the Agent should remember long-term directly into MEMORY.md
- 👀 **Observe Agent autonomous maintenance**: After the Agent runs for a period of time, look at the content automatically accumulated in MEMORY.md
- 🔄 **Manage memory content**: Regularly check and organize MEMORY.md, remove outdated information, ensuring long-term memory remains refined and accurate